

LADY VICTORIA
designs

Before You Book the Venue

The Essential Wedding Venue Checklist

A COMPLIMENTARY GUIDE FROM LADY VICTORIA DESIGNS

A NOTE BEFORE YOU TOUR

The venue comes *first*

The venue is the first big decision you make, and nearly every decision after it depends on it.

Your guest count, your menu, your décor, your timeline, even the way your guests arrive: all of it has to fit inside the rules of the room you choose. A venue can be breathtaking on a tour and still be unable to support the celebration you are planning.

This checklist holds the questions our planners ask on every venue tour. Take it with you, ask the ones that apply, and do not pay a deposit until the answers that matter are in writing.



With care, Irene

IRENE NTIAKO · FOUNDER & CREATIVE DIRECTOR

START HERE

Before you contact *a single venue*

The venue search often goes wrong when couples start by touring. Start by deciding. These six steps can save you weeks, and tours of venues that were never right for you.

01 **Set your overall wedding budget first**

The most important decision before choosing a venue. Agree on the total for the whole wedding: it tells you how much you can give the venue, and which vendors fit the rest.

02 **Choose your months, then your dates**

Pick two months you would be happy to marry in, then two or three dates inside them. Every venue conversation then starts with availability, not guesswork.

03 **Decide how far you'll go, and how far your guests will**

Pick a region, not a single city: in the DMV, maybe Maryland, DC, and Virginia. Then set a limit on how far you'll drive to tour, and how far guests will travel, hotels and airports included.

04 **Decide your style**

A hotel ballroom, a standalone ballroom, an industrial space, a barn, an estate or garden. And decide whether you want a space that is already beautiful, or an empty canvas to transform.

05 **Decide how your day flows**

Ceremony, cocktail hour, and reception all in one place? A church ceremony, then a reception venue nearby? An outdoor ceremony? These answers change which venues can work.

06 **Build your shortlist, then email before you tour**

We recommend listing five to ten venues that fit, then emailing each one with your guest count to ask for a rough total cost and a video walkthrough of the space.

YOUR STARTING POINT

Our total budget	Wedding: $_____ Venue: $_____
My two months	
My dates	
My area	
How far we'll go	Us: _____ hours Our guests: _____ hours
My style	
My flow	◯ All in one venue ◯ Church + reception ◯ Outdoor ceremony
My shortlist	

THEN NARROW WITH FACTS

The estimates and the videos will cut your list to two or three serious contenders. Tour only those, in person, with this checklist in hand.

IF YOU ONLY ASK TEN

10 questions to *never leave a tour without*

Each one is starred ★ in the checklist, with room for the answer and the name of the person who gave it.

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01 What time does everything have to end: music, the bar, guests, and vendors packing up?
An early end time changes the whole shape of the day.

02 How many guests can the room really seat once the dance floor, stage, bars, and lounge areas are in?
A room listed for 200 may seat far fewer with your layout.

03 Can we see the rain-backup space, and does it fit all our guests?
A rain plan only helps if you would be happy celebrating in it.

04 Do we have to use the venue's caterer, pick from their list, or can we bring our own?
If you must use theirs, the menu and the price are largely decided for you.

05 Exactly how many hours do we get to set up décor before guests arrive?
If the answer is two, the design you are picturing may not fit.

06 Can large installations get into the room without stairs or tight turns?
If the big pieces cannot get in, the design changes, however beautiful the room.

07 Can florals, chandeliers, or draping hang from the ceiling?
Hanging installations are often the first thing a venue says no to.

08 Does the quote include everything: venue fee, service charge, tax, staffing, security, cleaning, rentals, parking, valet, power, and overtime?
Service charges, tax, and overtime are rarely in the first number.

09 Can our guest count go down after we sign, or only up?
Sign for 200, have 150 come, and you may still pay for 200.

10 What deposit and payment schedule do you require, and what happens if we cancel or postpone?
Know what you would lose before you pay, not after.

THE ONE RULE

“We’re flexible” *is not a yes*

Here is how it can happen. On the tour, you mention that your caterer will cook on site, and the coordinator smiles and says, “We’re very flexible.” Months later, the contract arrives, and it says outside food must arrive fully prepared. Nothing was promised in writing, so nothing was promised.

> BEFORE YOU SIGN
>
> *If a promise affects your ceremony, décor, food, music, parking, guest count, budget, or timeline, ask for it in writing.*

IF YOU HEAR THIS, SLOW DOWN

- “We’re flexible,” with nothing in writing behind it.
- Only an hour or two to set up before guests arrive.
- The rain-backup space can’t hold everyone, or you wouldn’t want to use it.
- The quote leaves out the service charge, tax, or overtime.



HOW TO USE THIS CHECKLIST

One box, *three marks*

01 Before the tour

Read it through and cross out anything that does not apply to your wedding.

02 On the tour

Ask each question and mark its box. For starred questions, write down the answer and who said it.

03 After the tour

Copy every slash onto the Chase List at the back, and email it to the venue to confirm in writing.

04 Before you sign

Anything still not in writing becomes a change to request in the contract, or a reason to keep looking.

☐ EMPTY
Not asked yet.

☑ SLASH
Asked, and told yes out loud.

☑ CHECK
Confirmed by email or in the contract.

★ DEALBREAKERS
The questions that can end a venue. Get the answer and the name of the person who gave it.

VERDICT
At the end of each section, circle Clear, Needs follow-up, or Dealbreaker. Flip through later and see where you stand.

WHAT TO BRING TO THE TOUR

- Your guest count, and the most it could grow to
- Your wedding date, or the dates you are considering
- Your budget range for the venue
- Photos of your design inspiration
- A list of your ceremonies, traditions, and must-haves
- Your phone, for photos and video of every room, door, and entrance
- This checklist and a pen
- Your planner or designer, if you have one



01 Date, Hours & Curfew

Setup, the celebration, and cleanup all come out of the same rental hours.

- [ ] What time can our vendors start setting up, and when does setup have to be finished?
- [ ] ★ What time does everything have to end: music, the bar, guests, and vendors packing up?
  An early end time changes the whole shape of the day.

  ANSWER _____ WHO SAID IT _____
- [ ] What does it cost if we run over time, and is that charged by the half hour or the hour?
  Listen for: whether staff and security are charged on top of the room.
- [ ] Is there a local noise rule that ends outdoor music earlier than the venue's own curfew?
- [ ] Is any other event happening at the venue on the same day?

VERDICT ◯ Clear ◯ Needs follow-up ◯ Dealbreaker

02 Real Capacity & Layout

The capacity on the brochure is usually for an empty room. Your dance floor, stage, bars, and décor all take seats away.

- [ ] ★ How many guests can the room really seat once the dance floor, stage, bars, and lounge areas are in?
  A room listed for 200 may seat far fewer with your layout.

  ANSWER _____ WHO SAID IT _____
- [ ] ★ Can we see the rain-backup space, and does it fit all our guests?
  A rain plan only helps if you would be happy celebrating in it.

  ANSWER _____ WHO SAID IT _____
- [ ] If the weather turns, by what time do we have to decide, and are tents, heaters, or flooring allowed?
- [ ] If the ceremony and reception are in the same room, where do guests wait during the changeover, and does it fit everyone?
  Listen for: how long the changeover takes. A cocktail space that's too small is a common surprise.
- [ ] How many restrooms are there, and are they enough for our guest count?
  Listen for: a number, not "plenty."
- [ ] Is there a getting-ready space for both sides, and can hair and makeup work on site?

VERDICT ◯ Clear ◯ Needs follow-up ◯ Dealbreaker

03 Alcohol & Bar

Whoever holds the license decides who pours and when the bar closes.

- [ ] Does the venue have its own liquor license, or do we need a permit?
- [ ] What time does the bar have to close, and what bar fees are there?

FOR YOUR PLANNER: *who arranges the permit, bartenders, security, and liquor insurance, and whether the venue must be named on the policy.*

VERDICT ◯ Clear ◯ Needs follow-up ◯ Dealbreaker

04 Catering & Kitchen

If your caterer cannot cook the way your menu needs, the meal you are picturing may not be possible here.

- [ ] ★ Do we have to use the venue's caterer, pick from their list, or can we bring our own?
  If you must use theirs, the menu and the price are largely decided for you.

  ANSWER _____ WHO SAID IT _____
- [ ] Can our caterer cook on site?
- [ ] Can dietary and allergy needs be met?
- [ ] Is there a food and drink minimum, and is it lower on off-peak days or seasons?
  A minimum isn't a quote: tax and service charges often come on top.

VERDICT ◯ Clear ◯ Needs follow-up ◯ Dealbreaker

05 What's Included

"Included" can mean anything. The chairs may be included; the chairs you want may not be.

- [ ] Which tables, chairs, linens, place settings, bars, and dance floor are included?
- [ ] Can we see the included pieces, and what costs extra to deliver, set up, or clean?
  "Included" chairs can turn out to be the wrong color, or the glassware plastic. Seeing them is the only way to know.
- [ ] Can the dance floor be wrapped or covered?

VERDICT ◯ Clear ◯ Needs follow-up ◯ Dealbreaker

06 Décor Setup & Load-In

Your design is only as good as the hours and the access you get to install it.

- [ ] ★ Exactly how many hours do we get to set up décor before guests arrive?
  If the answer is two, the design you are picturing may not fit.
  ANSWER _____ WHO SAID IT _____
- [ ] How many hours do we get afterwards to take everything down?
- [ ] Can setup start the day before, and can décor stay overnight?
- [ ] ★ Can large installations get into the room without stairs or tight turns?
  If the big pieces cannot get in, the design changes, however beautiful the room.
  ANSWER _____ WHO SAID IT _____
- [ ] What time does the room have to be guest-ready?
- [ ] Are real candles allowed, and are there rules on the holders (floating only, enclosed)?
  Some venues allow only floating candles, which can change a whole design.
- [ ] What can be attached to the walls, ceiling, or floor, and are tape, confetti, loose petals, or sparklers allowed?

FOR YOUR PLANNER: *whether the room is on the loading level, the dock or service entrance, and measuring the path from the truck to the room.*

VERDICT ○ Clear ○ Needs follow-up ○ Dealbreaker

NOTES

07 Lighting, Effects & Power

Lighting, music, hanging florals, and first-dance effects all need permission, and power.

- [ ] ★ Can florals, chandeliers, or draping hang from the ceiling?
  Hanging installations are often the first thing a venue says no to.

  ANSWER _____ WHO SAID IT _____

- [ ] Are special effects allowed, like cold sparks, a low cloud for the first dance, or haze?
- [ ] Is there backup power if the electricity goes out?

FOR YOUR PLANNER: *how much power the room has for lighting, music, and catering, the ceiling rigging points, and approvals for effects.*

VERDICT ◯ Clear ◯ Needs follow-up ◯ Dealbreaker

08 Parking & Arrival

Arrival is your guests' first impression. A long walk in the rain is hard to undo.

- [ ] How many guest parking spaces are there?
- [ ] Is parking free, validated, or paid by guests?
- [ ] Is valet required or optional, and what does it cost?
- [ ] Where do guests get dropped off, including shuttles, rideshare, and accessible drop-off?
- [ ] Is there overflow parking, and would we need a shuttle?
- [ ] Is the walk from parking safe, accessible, and well lit in bad weather?
- [ ] How far is it from the hotels your guests will use, and from the nearest airport?

VERDICT ◯ Clear ◯ Needs follow-up ◯ Dealbreaker

NOTES

09 Cost, Contract & Your Contact

The quote is rarely the total, and the contract is the only promise that counts.

- [ ] ★ Does the quote include everything: venue fee, service charge, tax, staffing, security, cleaning, rentals, parking, valet, power, and overtime?

  Service charges, tax, and overtime are rarely in the first number.

  ANSWER _____ WHO SAID IT _____

- [ ] Are there admin or credit card fees on top of the service charge?

- [ ] ★ Can our guest count go down after we sign, or only up?

  Sign for 200, have 150 come, and you may still pay for 200.

  ANSWER _____ WHO SAID IT _____

- [ ] Will everything we've agreed go in the contract?

  If it was only said on the tour, it isn't promised.

- [ ] ★ What deposit and payment schedule do you require, and what happens if we cancel or postpone?

  Know what you would lose before you pay, not after.

  ANSWER _____ WHO SAID IT _____

- [ ] Will the person planning with us be the one there on the day?

  Some couples plan with one person and meet a stranger on the day.

VERDICT ○ Clear ○ Needs follow-up ○ Dealbreaker

NOTES

AFTER THE TOUR

Your *Chase List*

Copy every question you marked with a slash: asked, but not yet in writing. Email the list to the venue, and check each one off as it comes back.

QUESTION	WHO SAID IT	IN WRITING
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐

THE LAST STEP

Before You Sign

01 Get a complete, itemized quote.

02 Have your designer check load-in, rigging, and power.

03 Make sure every approval you were given is in the contract.

LADY VICTORIA
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Lady Victoria Designs provides luxury wedding planning and full-room event design with thoughtful logistics, strong client advocacy, refined aesthetics, and celebrations that honor each couple's priorities and traditions.

Touring venues and want a second set of eyes? We invite you to schedule a design consultation.

Bring this checklist and your venue contract — we will review the answers with you and help you confirm the venue can support the celebration you are envisioning.

SCHEDULE A CONSULTATION

TEXT	(301) 312-0332
ONLINE	ladyvictoriadesigns.com

